

A Study of Conquest: Napoleon's Reign

My comprehensive analysis on Ambition and Cowardice.



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Napoleon Bonaparte (1769 - 1821)

Ambition

Since the dawn of human evolution, we homo sapiens have had to fight our way through several species of more or less our own kind. From our coexistence with the Neanderthals to competing with them for resources, everything was done for the most fundamental function of a living organism, something very primal and innate in our being, Survival. It's said that "As a single unit your goal is to survive, as a team it's to thrive". We did.

We've been very fortunate. But we're no longer fighting another species for resource land or shelter. We've no quarrel. What's propelling the world forward now? People will argue it's curiosity, greed, lust for power. I'd argue it's Ambition, the willingness to achieve.

Napoleon is the embodiment of this Ambition. All the glory and conquest, powered and propelled by Ambition. Starting off from a small island of Corsica to crown himself emperor of France only to be exiled to Elba, return, and taking it all back to again, be exiled to St. Helena. Ambition had always been a catalyst to his lust for knowledge, his patriotism to his country, his competence as war general and his competitiveness against the countries of the coalition. Nothing motivated him to sail the seas to Egypt other than his relentless pursuit of expansion which was driven by vision of French supremacy, and that vision was planted by ambition itself. Ambition to weaken the British power and expand French influence in the Mediterranean. It's something so innate in one's core, it can't be replicated. He sailed the seas with grand dreams of conquest, believing that his ambition would reshape the balance of power. That kind of audacity can only come from someone whose vision surpasses the immediate horizon, someone who sees beyond the now.

Common with every great emperor and inventor. It's a privilege if you wake up, and somehow an idea emerges in your mind, planted like a seed which compels you, empowers you to sail the seven seas, go on an Odyssey and conquer a land known to no man. It is the force that wakes you up with ideas so grand they feel like prophecy.

People would often confuse Ambition with Passion. If you're not Ambitious with your Passion, you'll get nowhere. Absolutely nowhere.

And so, the question arises, how does one generate Ambition?

Imagination: The Source of Ambition

Imagination. In today's world, where immediacy often overshadows depth, the ability to truly leverage imagination is rare. People have lost the ability to leverage their most primal element, Imagination. Are you able to give yourself goosebumps via your imagination? Is your imagination visceral enough? Is it feral and wild enough to go through the world untamed? Is it as organic and unrefined as you need it to be? Probably no.

You must envision yourself achieving something so vividly it's almost like seeing through time. Envisage the future. That's what I believe.



The *Napoleonic Wars* (1803–1815)

Cowardice

Vince Lombardi was famously quoted saying “Fatigue makes cowards of us all”. He indeed was right. So was Napoleon when he quoted “In war, moral is to the physical three is to one”. I understand why he said it, most would attribute it towards his opinion on morale of his soldiers and their physical competence during war. That’s why I believe he said it, at least that’s not all.

Take Napoleon’s Egyptian campaign, a stark moment of reflection on ambition and limits. After suffering a devastating blow from the British in the Battle of the Nile, French Navy’s ability to operate in the Mediterranean was crippled. French soldiers were left stranded in the scorching land of Egypt. The desert stretched endlessly before them, and soon the ambition of a Mediterranean conquest began to feel like distant echo while the dunes start to prune the French patriots, one at a time.

In the black of night. Napoleon left. Covertly. Forsaking his men to the sands of Egypt. Evoking a vivid feeling of desolation behind in their hearts. Whether he did it for the necessity of him being alive for the future of France, or him apprehending or perhaps conceiving the idea that fatigue does indeed makes cowards of all, is up to debate. And this is why I think he said it. Not as his observation of other people, but as a result of him reflecting upon himself and his deeds. As after a year of withstanding the sand even he had his limits.

Logically, his decision to abandon his men could be attributed towards the philosophy of “knowing what battles to fight, and what battles to back down from”. It’s wise. Emotionally, there’s a lot to scrutinize him for. Although he’s no coward, it was a form of cowardice.

Modern Cowardice

But cowardice is the most relevant in this day and age as most people are afraid to speak up, afraid to act out, afraid to lay their thoughts down in their rawest form for the world to see. Because whatever Napoleon did in regard to “cowardice” pales in

comparison to the cowardice displayed by people every single day—where people are often too afraid to pursue their full potential.

Cowardice, in its truest form is to not be what you are. Greatest sin? To be a fraction of what you could be.

Conclusion

Napoleon's life is a testament to the power of ambition. His conquest reshaped Europe, his ambition unmatched and unparalleled. Forcing multiple countries to a coalition 7 times, all to stop one man leading a country. It demonstrates the exceptionalism of absolute ambition which includes both good and bad.

In the end, the question is not whether we have ambition or cowardice, but how we choose to navigate between the two. Will we rise like Napoleon, driven by imagination and vision? Or will we let fear hold us back, only to wonder what might have been?

Because sometimes, cowardice isn't about fleeing from battle—it's about fleeing from responsibility, from the very ideals that once fueled your ambition.

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